11.5 Gravity in an Accelerating Train

WORKSHEET

The question

STEP II 2021, Question 10

Read the question before you go on. It is in the STEP II paper in OCR's download of the 2021 STEP papers (a zip file):

www.ocr.org.uk/Images/696588-2021-past-papers.zip

Hints

Try the question on your own first. If you get stuck, read the hints *one at a time*, and go back to the question after each one. Hints marked *Pause and try* are the key steps.

Ask yourself The train accelerates westwards (in the negative x direction) at a. For an observer in the train, what "fictitious" force appears to act on a mass m?

STAGE 2 An energy equation

Ask yourself Write Newton's law in the train's frame, including the normal reaction $\mathbf{N}$. Then take the dot product with the velocity $(\dot{x}, \dot{y})$. Why does $\mathbf{N}$ disappear?

STAGE 3 How high?

Ask yourself The constant is 0, since the bead starts at rest at the origin. At the highest point the bead is momentarily at rest. What equation does that give?

STAGE 4 The fastest point

Ask yourself Write the speed squared as a function of x alone. Where is it greatest?

Ask yourself Find the gradient of the wire at $x = \frac{ak}{2g}$. How does it relate to the direction of the effective gravity $(a, -g)$?

Try this next

1. **A cannon on a train.** Try STEP I 2000, Question 9 (step.maths.org/questions/00-s1-q9): a projectile fired inside an accelerating carriage, where the acceleration acts like a tilt in gravity.
2. **A headwind.** Try STEP II 2006, Question 11 (step.maths.org/questions/06-s2-q11): a projectile against a constant wind, which can blow it back towards you before it lands.
3. **Coffee in a train.** Show that the surface of a cup of coffee in the accelerating train is a plane tilted at angle $\arctan(a/g)$ to the horizontal.
4. **Small oscillations.** Find the period of small oscillations of the bead about $x = \frac{ak}{2g}$.

(*Hint:* near the new bottom the wire is approximately a circle of radius equal to its radius of curvature.)

Further reading

- **Daniel Kleppner & Robert Kolenkow, *An Introduction to Mechanics*** (Cambridge University Press), the chapter on non-inertial frames and fictitious forces.
- **Albert Einstein, *Relativity: The Special and the General Theory*** (various editions). Einstein's own popular account, including the accelerating box.
- **Pedro Ferreira, *The Perfect Theory*** (Little, Brown). A biography of general relativity.

The full guided solution, and what the question leads to at university, is in Section 11.5: https://beyondstep.keithmcnulty.org/ch11/accelerating-frame.html